

By and through

Teaching guide

Explain a method or a process without changing the meaning.

Understand the distinction

By often introduces how something is done: by checking the map, by train, by email.

Through can present a route, a channel, or a process: through the park, through an agency, through regular practice.

By + -ing and through + noun are useful starting patterns, not a complete rule. Both words have other uses. Both can introduce a method in some contexts: by working together / through working together. By highlights how; through can highlight the process.

Compare the patterns

METHOD

I saved time by booking online.

Booking is the action that helped.

PROCESS

She gained confidence through practice.

Practice is the process behind the change.

ROUTE

We walked through the station.

Through describes movement from one part to another.

Read each example and notice how its form changes the meaning. Use these distinctions to choose your answers on the following pages.

Check your understanding

Circle one answer for each question. There is one correct choice among the options shown. Check the answer key after choosing.

1. Complete with an -ing form: I checked the time by ___ at my phone.

- A. look
- B. looked
- C. looking

2. We found our apartment through an agency. How did the agency help?

- A. The agency connected us with the apartment or its owner.
- B. The agency tells us how long the search lasted.
- C. The agency was the route we physically walked through.

3. Is by always followed by an -ing verb? Choose the statement with a valid example.

- A. No. By can only be followed by a person.
- B. Yes. Every use of by must have an -ing verb.
- C. No: by train, by email, or by Friday.

Choose the best response

Choose the response that fits the situation. Check both its meaning and its grammar.

4. Which pair correctly describes a learning method and a process that builds confidence?

- A. I learn phrases by writing examples. I gain confidence through regular conversations.
- B. I learn phrases by writing examples. I gain confidence through to converse.
- C. I learn phrases by write examples. I gain confidence through regular conversations.

Review your choices

Use the answer explanations on the next page. If you chose a different answer, find the detail that makes it unsuitable and try the question again.

Practice online

The web lesson gives feedback for the option you select and lets you try again. No written response is required.

Answers and explanation

1. C. looking

By looking explains the method.

A: By takes the -ing form when followed by this action: by looking.

B: Looked is not the -ing form required after by in this pattern.

2. A. The agency connected us with the apartment or its owner.

Through identifies the intermediary: someone or an organization that helps connect two sides.

B: Through an agency identifies who helped connect the two sides, not a duration.

C: Here through identifies an intermediary, not a physical passage.

3. C. No: by train, by email, or by Friday.

The form depends on the meaning and phrase.

A: By email, by train, and by Friday do not name people.

B: Phrases such as by train and by Friday show that other patterns are possible.

4. A. I learn phrases by writing examples. I gain confidence through regular conversations.

By writing describes the method; through conversations identifies a helpful process.

B: Through to converse is not this pattern. Use through conversations or through conversing.

C: Use the -ing form after by in this method phrase: by writing.

Continue learning

Web lesson and related topics: englishladder.com/grammar-concepts/concept-05.html

A practical teaching sequence

1. Notice (2 minutes)

Read the comparison examples with the learners. Point out the meaning and form that distinguish each pattern.

2. Choose (4 minutes)

Learners select one option for each of the three checks. Keep the answer key covered. Use the selected option's explanation rather than presenting a generic model as feedback.

3. Apply (5 minutes)

Which pair correctly describes a learning method and a process that builds confidence?

Learners choose the response that fits this situation. All responses in this activity are multiple choice; do not replace the choices with a written-answer task.

4. Review (3 minutes)

Compare selected options with the key. Use the option-specific notes to explain why a distractor does not fit. Let learners change their selection and try again.

Scope of the answer key

Each question has one correct option among the choices shown. This does not mean that every other way to express the idea is wrong. Preserve the qualifications in the teaching notes.

Feedback criteria

Check both grammatical form and the stated situation. A correct option answers this question; four correct choices do not certify a learner's overall proficiency.